"I'm not staring, I'm analyzing the gradient," Gimli grumbled, though there was a distinct lack of heat in his voice. He traced a thick finger over the jagged lines of the White Mountains, his eyes narrowing at a particularly steep descent. "The Dwarves of the Blue Mountains had a theory about gravitational acceleration on snow, but I suspect the theory was largely based on falling down a very steep hill very quickly."

The map lay sprawled across a flat rock, weighted down by a stray piece of shale and a half-eaten apple. Around them, the air of the highlands was crisp and thin, carrying the scent of old stone and frozen pine. Aragorn stood a few paces away, his gaze fixed on the shimmering white expanse of the peak above them. He wasn't looking at the terrain for tactical advantage or hidden paths; he was adjusting the leather straps on his boots, ensuring the heavy, curved planks of polished ash were bolted securely to his soles.